Jimmy Lee 李兆康

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Fellow in Economics Sept 2024 – Present
Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

Visiting Scholar Jan 2025 – June 2026
Center for International Development, Harvard University

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, Northwestern University 2024
M.Phil., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2017
B.SSc., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2015

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Program Evaluation
Focus—Synergies between Agriculture and Rural Education

Behavioral Economics, Labor Economics
Focus—The Economics of Curiosity and Capability Development under Cognitive Limits

Family Economics, Organizational Economics
Focus—Intergenerational Dynamics in Rural Household and Community Decision Making

TEACHING AND AI TRAINING

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University (Department median 5.3/6)
Introduction to Microeconomics (5.2, 5.4, 5.6), Introduction to Macroeconomics (5.4, 5.4), Intermediate Microeconomics (5.4), Intermediate Macroeconomics (5.7), International Trade (5.6), Economics of Nonprofit Organizations (5.8)

Teaching Assistant, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
Mathematical Methods in Economics I, II, Family Economics, Labor Economics, International Macroeconomics

AI Trainer – Economics Expert (Flex time) Apr 2026 – Oct 2026
Stress-testing performance on PhD-level microeconomic questions at SpaceXSI

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Misinterpretation as an Information Friction? Activating School-Based Agricultural Education in Liberia with Parental Engagement"
(Funded by AFD Fund for Innovation in Development, USAID-DIV, Wellspring Foundation, and FAO)

Many developing countries have understaffed agricultural extension systems, which slow technology diffusion and, through stagnant yields, pressure households to keep children out of school. This paper demonstrates an innovative school-based approach that breaks this chain, but only if parent-school linkages are strengthened. In a three-year experiment across 197 Liberian schools, I evaluate school-based agricultural education (SBAE), a voluntary program training science teachers to integrate inquiry-based learning with student-led school farms and home projects, so that schooling carries an informational return on farming techniques. Across SBAE schools, I cross-randomize parental engagement treatments, a promotional video and an annual field day, comparing SBAE with and without this combination. With engagement, SBAE improves targeted outcomes: students' households adopt 26–53% more yield-improving farming techniques, dropouts fall 4–5 percentage points per year, and absenteeism falls 28%. It ranks among the most cost-effective programs for technology adoption and school attendance. SBAE trains teachers and students effectively regardless of parental engagement, but without engagement its two diffusion channels, parents' visits to school farms and students' home projects, stay muted. Technology adoption vanishes, educational inputs fall, and parents disconnect: fewer than half visit school farms in three years, and parent–teacher meetings fall 39%. Parents' persistent avoidance of information, plus sharply reversed outcomes under engagement, presents a puzzle: Bayesian updating with a single prior, selective attention, and associative memory each fall short. I propose an integrative explanation: engagement shifts parents away from viewing agriculture and education as substitutes, a view that would persist if parents misperceive SBAE as typical school gardens based on pure chores.

WORKING PAPERS

1. **"Endogenous Model Uncertainty and Curiosity under Cognitive Limits"**

   How does a cognitively limited mind decide not only what to learn, but what is worth asking in the first place? Neuroscience suggests that people automatically classify situations through familiar mental models (e.g., a farmer attributing a neighbor's high yield to good weather), entertaining alternatives when observations become difficult to reconcile with their initial interpretation. This paper treats such shifts in "mindsets" as a choice of how much model uncertainty to entertain. Each mental model pairs a prior with a view of how observable features combine to reveal the state. After an initial signal, a decision maker with a costless default and latent alternatives with less precise priors jointly chooses model weights and how many signals to acquire. The key discipline is an evidence constraint that bounds motivated beliefs: an alternative's weight is capped by its Bayesian posterior. Curiosity emerges as the value of resolving the model uncertainty the decision maker entertains. Two results follow. First, the evidence constraint interacts with a complementarity between model weights and information acquisition to produce curiosity failures: people may fail to investigate explanations that could change their minds. Second, because the brain weighs all explanations on the menu against the same evidence, a plausible explanation the decision maker would never act on can stifle her investigation of a promising one—distinguishing the theory from other behavioral models. Keeping the menu small thus becomes central: I endogenize it, formalizing creative and critical thinking as complementary forms of cognitive dimension reduction that together sustain curiosity. I illustrate the theory throughout with development programs, teacher training, and agricultural technology adoption.

2. **"Technology Adoption and Schooling as Complements: The Promise of School-Based Agricultural Education in Africa"** (joint with Christopher Udry)

   In sub-Saharan Africa, wide heterogeneity across farms makes other households' experience a noisy guide to what suits a household's own farms, slowing technology diffusion, while low perceived returns to schooling drive students to drop out. We develop a model of why school-based agricultural education (SBAE), a holistic program in which trained science teachers integrate inquiry-based learning with student-led school demonstration farms and home farming projects, addresses this dual problem. Our model builds on the target-input framework, in which a household learns a technology's suitability only by using it in production or by observing others who do. We add a third channel: the more of a child's time the household devotes to schooling, the more precisely it learns from the school's production signals. Schooling and technology adoption become complements. First, schooling carries an option value on the farm: by raising the probability of future adoption, it makes attendance worthwhile even where labor-market returns are low. Second, SBAE effectively subsidizes information acquisition by delivering information through schooling, whose cost households already bear for its educational returns, countering the under-supply of information in the presence of learning spillovers. We provide experimental evidence from Liberia that SBAE cost-effectively raises both agricultural technology adoption and school attendance. The model serves as a springboard for studying how SBAE can be strengthened by (i) developing teachers' and students' scientific capabilities to acquire and adapt agricultural knowledge, and (ii) turning schools into hubs that pool households' dispersed knowledge and feed it back.

3. **"Can Communicating Parents' Beliefs to Students Be a Pivotal Component of Parental Engagement? Evidence from School-Based Agricultural Education in Liberia"**

   (Funded by NSF, Weiss Fund, Global Poverty Research Lab, and the Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)

   When school programs require students to introduce improved techniques on household farms, is informing students and parents about the program sufficient, or is there a case for further signaling parents' support to students? I study this question within a randomized evaluation of school-based agricultural education (SBAE) in Liberia, where students take school farm training into a home farming project. After parents view a promotional video of the program and students are encouraged to diffuse techniques to their parents, I randomize a nudge revealing to students their parents' optimism about their farm-management skills. Two years later, SBAE improves students' livelihoods only with the nudge: income rises 63%, on-time school fee payment 43–47%, and cost-effectiveness for attendance doubles. Analysis of mechanisms highlights a management aspect of agricultural technology adoption that can be addressed with nudges: even where parents become attentive to SBAE and adopt promoted techniques, third-party assurance can be pivotal in shifting students away from assisting in subsistence farming.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Ongoing Randomized Experiments (scaling SBAE across Liberia, Côte d'Ivoire, and Kenya in 2026-35)

1. **"Learning to Learn: Synergizing Inquiry-based Science and Agricultural Transformation in Liberia"** (joint with Vesall Nourani, Harvard GSE; scheduled RCT within the scaling of SBAE in 2026-29)

2. **"School-based Agricultural Education, Parental Engagement, and the Use of Unconditional Cash Transfers"** (piloted interventions in 2025-26)
3. **"Directed Technical Change under Data-Driven Farming Advice: An Empirical Framework"** (grant from Weiss Fund; piloted survey method; planning RCT)

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Total program evaluation and academic research grants secured for SBAE in Liberia: **$4.2 million**

Program Evaluation Grants

AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI)	2025
J-PAL Learning for All Initiative: Scaling Award ($222K; co-PI)	2024
USAID Development Innovation Ventures ($395K; co-PI)	2022
Wellspring Foundation ($192K; co-PI)	2022
AFD Fund for Innovation in Development ($1.2 mil; co-PI)	2021
Food and Agriculture Organization ($68K; co-PI)	2021

Academic Research Awards

J-PAL Learning for All Initiative ($400K; co-PI)	2025
Weiss Fund ($5K; Lead PI)	2022
National Science Foundation ($451K; co-PI)	2020
Weiss Fund ($29K; Lead PI)	2020
Global Poverty Research Lab ($19K; Lead PI)	2019
Buffett Institute for Global Affairs ($5K; Lead PI)	2019

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

During postdoctoral studies:

Mundlak Workshop in Agricultural and Applied Economics (scheduled); National Chung Cheng University; NYU Africa House–Center for Technology, Economics, and Development (CTED); Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P); Tel Aviv University; Oklahoma State University; Harvard Center for International Development; Africa Food Systems Forum 2024

During PhD:

Meeting of the Society of Economics of the Household (SEHO); J-PAL—Middle East and North Africa (MENA); CGIAR—Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA); International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI); University of Glasgow; National Graduate Institute for Policy Studies (GRIPS, Tokyo); Development Day 2023

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Citizenship: Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, China
Languages: English (fluent), French (intermediate), Mandarin (fluent), Cantonese (native)
Programming: Stata, R, Matlab, Python, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

REFERENCES

Professor Christopher Udry (Chair)
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Professor Lori Beaman
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